CHAPTER 2

Plural nouns

1. Nominative plural

The nominative plural article is **ðā** for all three genders. A noun retains its gender in the plural.

se fisc → **ðā fiscas**; **sēo wyrt** → **ðā wyrta**; **ðæt dēor** → **ðā dēor**.

Plural formation depends on declension, not gender alone. The following patterns occur in this lesson:

Pattern	Example
Masculine **-as**	**fisc** → **fiscas**
Feminine **-a**	**wyrt** → **wyrta**
Neuter **-u**	**nīeten** → **nīetenu**
Neuter, no added ending	**dēor** → **dēor**

Stem changes accompany some endings: **dæg** → **dagas**, **hwæl** → **hwalas**; **fugol** → **fuglas**, **morgen** → **morgnas**, **tācen** → **tācnu**. **trēo** has **w** before the ending: **trēowu**. Nouns in **-nes** have **-nessa**. Learn **niht**, **męnn**, and **sǣs** individually.

Neuter -u and zero. The neuters in §2 belong to the strong declension. In monosyllabic strong neuters, a light stem—a short vowel or short diphthong followed by one consonant—normally takes **-u**. A heavy stem—a long vowel or long diphthong, or a short vowel or diphthong followed by two or more consonants (including a doubled consonant)—normally has no ending. Thus **gēar, dēor, sǣd** remain unchanged.

Supplied illustrations, not vocabulary for recall: **hof** → **hofu**, dwelling(s); **word** → **word**, word(s).

Two-syllable nouns vary; a heavy first syllable followed by a light second syllable often gives **-u**: **nīetenu, æfenu**. Some lose the second vowel before **-u**: **tācen** → **tācnu**. Retain the forms in §2. **trēo** → **trēowu** follows a separate pattern despite its long diphthong.

The nominative plural is used for plural subjects and for the isolated phrases below. Coordinate definite phrases as before: article + noun, **and**, article + noun.

2. Vocabulary

All forms are nominative. New headwords: **sǣ**, **hwæl**, **nīeten**. The other headwords are familiar; all twenty-two plural forms are new.

Singular	Gender	Plural	Meaning
dæg	m.	**dagas**	day
niht	f.	**niht**	night
fisc	m.	**fiscas**	fish
fugol	m.	**fuglas**	bird
trēo	n.	**trēowu**	tree
wyrt	f.	**wyrta**	herb; plant
andlīcnes	f.	**andlīcnessa**	image
gelīcnes	f.	**gelīcnessa**	likeness
tācen	n.	**tācnu**	sign
tīd	f.	**tīda**	season; time
gēar	n.	**gēar**	year
mann	m.	**męnn**	man; human being
dēor	n.	**dēor**	animal; beast
sǣ	m.	**sǣs**	sea
heofon	m.	**heofonas**	heaven; sky
sǣd	n.	**sǣd**	seed
wæstm	m.	**wæstmas**	fruit; produce
ǣfen	n.	**ǣfenu**	evening
morgen	m.	**morgnas**	morning
gāst	m.	**gāstas**	spirit
hwæl	m.	**hwalas**	whale
nīeten	n.	**nīetenu**	animal; beast; in the plural, cattle

3. Preparation

1. Put into the nominative plural: **se dæg**; **sēo wyrt**; **ðæt dēor**.
2. Give the nominative plural of **fugol**, **tācen**, **mann**.
3. Give the meaning and gender of **sǣ**, **hwæl**, **nīeten**.

4. Composition

Translate into Old English. Use the vocabulary of §2, nominative plural forms, an article before each noun, and **and**.

1. The days and the nights.
2. The fishes and the birds.
3. The trees and the herbs.
4. The images and the likenesses.
5. The signs and the seasons.
6. The years and the days.
7. The men and the animals.
8. The seas and the heavens.
9. The seeds and the fruits.
10. The evenings and the mornings.
11. The spirits and the men.
12. The whales and the cattle.

5. Reading and translation

A clause from God's blessing of the living creatures in the Creation narrative. The following forms are supplied, not assigned for independent recall.

Form	Meaning and analysis
bēon	be; present plural optative (subjunctive), here expressing a command or wish: "let … be."
gemanigfielde	multiplied; increased in number. Past participle, masculine nominative plural.
ofer	over; across. Preposition.
eorðan	earth; oblique singular of **eorðe** after **ofer**.

bēon gemanigfielde, "let … be multiplied"; **ofer eorðan**, "over/across the earth."

and ðā fuglas bēon gemanigfielde ofer eorðan.

Using the supplied forms, answer in English:

1. What is to increase, and where?
2. Identify the subject's article and noun; give gender, number, and case.
3. Translate the clause.

6. Review

For 1–2, use the taught vocabulary, nominative plural forms, an article before each noun, and **and**.

1. The seeds and the birds.
2. The whales and the seas.
3. Give the number of each phrase and explain the distinction: **ðæt sǣd**; **ðā sǣd**. Why does **sǣd** have no plural ending?

Notes on sources and editorial choices

Ex: A. S. Cook, *Exercises in Old English* (1895). **FB:** *A First Book in Old English*, 2nd ed. (1895). References use printed pages; full evidence and scan locators are in the editorial record.

1. **Grammar and vocabulary (§§1–2):** FB §§4, 17, 43, 46–47, 51–52, 84. Stem weight: §4, p.6; neuter endings and the supplied **hof/word** paradigms: §47, pp.32–33; disyllable variation, Rodríguez Ledesma (2022), §5. New headwords: Ex, s.v. cattle, p.42; sea, p.60; whale, p.67; **nīeten**, FB vocabulary p.307. **tācnu** and **morgnas** are corroborated by Bosworth–Toller, *tácn* and *morgen*. **ǣfenu** follows the neuter patterns in FB §47.1, 7; it is a grammatical formation, not a quoted occurrence. The key records alternatives to the selected forms.
2. **Correction C01 (§2; composition 9):** Short **æ** in **wæstm, wæstmas** continues Chapter 1's correction of Cook's **wǣstm**: Baker, *wæstm*; Stenroos (2024), p.118, Table 1.
3. **Exercises (§§3–6):** All twelve composition prompts preserve Ex, Group I, Exercise 2, p.1. Directions, examples, additional tasks, and model answers are new teaching material.
4. **Reading (§5):** FB, Reader I, p.126, printed lines 12–13. The extracted clause retains every word and vowel mark; cue 21 and the closing quotation mark belonging to the surrounding speech are omitted. **bēon**: §138, p.78; §193(a), p.103. **gemanigfielde**: p.126, note 19, and vocabulary p.293. The translation is independently prepared. The case of **eorðan** is not tested; the form permits accusative and dative analyses after **ofer**.